and big-ticket projects to showcase its 'double-engine' government.

The welfare pitch was evident in chief minister Basavaraj Bommai's February 17 state budget, where agriculture and women's empowerment were the dominant themes—the CM upped the limit for zero-interest, short-term loans for farmers to Rs 5 lakh from Rs 3 lakh, and doled out Rs 500 a month for landless female farm workers under the 'Gruhini Shakti' programme. However, with the Congress already having promised a monthly allowance of Rs 2,000 for every woman who heads a family, Bommai later doubled this to Rs 1,000.

On the development front, PM Narendra Modi is himself leading the charge—on February 27, while inaugurating a new airport in Shimoga, Modi dwelt on how infrastructure projects were reaching the state's Tier-2 and Tier-3 towns. On March 11, he is to throw open the 10-lane Bengaluru-Mysuru expressway. Since January, Modi has visited Karnataka on four occasions, and so has Union home minister Amit Shah.

With Karnataka heading to the polls in a few months, Bommai rode on the post-Covid recovery and better tax collections to increase his outlay on welfare programmes while managing a revenue surplus. "Other states have not come out of the net of revenue deficits," the CM said in the assembly last week, pointing out that Karnataka's current outstanding debt at 23.4 per cent of gross state domestic product (GSDP) was lower when compared to the debt burden of the other states in the south ruled by non-BJP governments. Though it was a vote-on-account budget—an interim arrangement that allows governments to meet expenses till polls—with Karnataka going to the polls in two months, the allocations nevertheless covered a wide range of social groups. For instance, free bus passes for 30 lakh working women, exemption of fees for about 8 lakh students in government colleges; enhanced diesel subsidies and housing for fisherfolk; 50 per cent subsidy for youth from Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes for the purchase of electric cargo vehicles; an increase in monthly honorarium to anganwadi and ASHA workers, cooks, home guards and librarians and insurance scheme for 16.5 lakh auto, taxi and lorry drivers and e-commerce delivery persons. Still, government employees, aggrieved that there was no announcement of pay revision in the budget, went on strike on March 1, following which the government swiftly ordered an interim salary hike of 17 per cent to end the agitation.

BOMMAI'S BUDGET LARGESSE

- Rs 1,000 a month for landless female farm workers
- Zero-interest, short-term loans for farmers increased to Rs 5 lakh from Rs 3 lakh
- Free bus passes for 3 million working women, fee exemption for 800,000 students in govt colleges
- For SC/ST youths, 50 per cent subsidy for buying e-cargo vehicles
- Increase in monthly salaries for anganwadi, ASHA workers, cooks, home guards, librarians
- Insurance scheme for auto, taxi, lorry drivers, e-commerce delivery persons

WITH POLLS ONLY MONTHS AWAY, BOMMAI RODE ON POST-COVID RECOVERY TO INCREASE OUTLAY ON WELFARE SCHEMES

More election sops are on the cards with the BJP working on its manifesto, especially since the Congress has been rolling out election guarantees since January. So far, the Congress has announced three major promises—free electricity of up to 200 units for every household, followed by a Rs 2,000 monthly allowance for women and distribution of 10 kg rice to below-poverty-line families, which is double the quantity they receive currently.

"Why didn't Congress implement these schemes when they were in power," asks BJP state general secretary N. Ravikumar. Pointing out that the Bommai government's budget outlay had for the first time crossed Rs 3 trillion (three lakh crore), Ravikumar says the schemes have touched every section that needed attention and that the BJP has already activated its booth-level connect to disseminate these measures.

The counter from the Leader of Opposition Siddaramaiah was that the government had announced 206 programmes in last year's budget, but 57 of these were yet to commence. Further, he argued that allocations to weaker sections did not match up to the numbers required, and pointed to the mandatory requirement to earmark funds for Dalit groups in proportion to their population under Karnataka's Scheduled Castes Sub-Plan/Tribal Sub-Plan (SCSP/TSP)Act. "As the budget size increases, allocation should also be enhanced. It's a betrayal," said Siddaramaiah. Bommai's 2023-24 budget accounted for a Rs 1,981 crore increase in SCSP/TSP grants, which takes the total allocation under this to Rs 30,215 crore. Overall, Rs 39,031 crore was earmarked for agriculture and allied activities, Rs 46,278 crore for women's empowerment and Rs 47,256 crore towards children's welfare. A battle of wits has commenced between the BJP and the Congress—the latter attacking the ruling party with corruption charges and the BJP flexing its organisational muscle to stay the course. But somewhere in those numbers, there may lurk a written destiny. ■